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Demanding more from social media + Limits of Newsom's empathy + Kalra amends police bill

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Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

Programming note: We're still offering a one-month free subscription to our Recall Watch texts! You'll get daily updates on the recall and will be the first to hear about our coverage. Plus, you can ask questions and get real responses from reporter Lara Korte. Normally subscriptions are $4/mo, but you can get the first month free by signing up with this link.

TRANSPARENT TECH

Via Hannah Wiley ...

If anyone has a Twitter account, or a Facebook page, an Instagram, YouTube, TikTok or whatever else I'm missing that's popped up online in recent years, it's no secret that things can get...ugly. And that false information can spread like wildfire. And content posted can lead to dangerous outcomes.

Tech companies have, at times, taken responsibility for how their platforms nurture fringe groups into fruition, usually when grilled by lawmakers who want to see an action plan on how to stem this trend.

Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, also wants some accountability.

Gabriel is introducing legislation today that would require social media platforms to publicly display their policies that quell false information, stop harassment, hate and extremism and protect users from foreign interference.

"Californians are becoming increasingly alarmed about the role of social media in promoting hate, disinformation, conspiracy theories, and extreme political polarization," Gabriel said in a written statement.

The proposal, AB 587, is backed by tech accountability activist groups that regularly lobby on social media practices at the state and national Capitols.

"Greater transparency can combat the rise of disinformation, hate speech, and calls to violence that are omnipresent on social media and destructive to our democracy," Ann M. Ravel, policy director at Decode Democracy and former chair of the Federal Election Commission. "To preserve our democracy, social media platforms must be accountable and transparent to the public, and this bill is an important step in that direction."

Gabriel said his bill would hold the tech companies accountable to the extremism allowed to flourish on their watch.

"It's long past time for these companies to provide real transparency into their content moderation practices," he said. "The public and policymakers deserve to know when and how social media companies are amplifying certain voices and silencing others."

NEWSOM EXPRESSES EMPATHY FOR RECALL SIGNERS

Via Lara Korte...

Gov. Gavin Newsom said last week he has "empathy" for some who signed the recall petition against him. But he was less sympathetic toward recall leaders.

Speaking at a vaccine site in Orange County Thursday, the governor said the recall is being promoted by white supremacists and those with views “completely antithetical” to California values.

“The principal sponsor of the recall, has stated that he believes that immigrants should have tags of sorts, said that they work for stray animals,” Newsom said. “That’s the principal proponent of recall. Other advocates are members of the Three Percenters, a white supremacy group. These are the principal proponents of this effort. These are not folks I align with in any way, shape or form. I find their views just completely antithetical to everything this state represents and what we’re about.”

But it’s been a tough year, Newsom acknowledged, and he doesn’t harbor ill will toward the 2.1 million Californians who have petitioned to remove him.

“There are people that signed that, that I have deep respect and empathy for, that have been frustrated. This has been a hard year for all of us,” he said. “And that stress is palpable, and it’s real. It’s understandable.

“But you’ve got to know where the origins of this thing lie.”

The original petition, in fact, doesn’t even mention the pandemic or Newsom’s shutdown orders. Instead, it lists taxes, homelessness, and immigration as problems that Newsom is responsible for.

“Governor Newsom has implemented laws which are detrimental to the citizens of this state and our way of life,” reads the petition, which has been signed by more than 2 million Californians.

“Laws he endorsed favor foreign nationals, in our country illegally, over that of our own citizens.

“People in this state suffer the highest taxes in the nation, the highest homelessness rates, and the lowest quality of life as a result.

We have more on the petition’s origins in this story today.

KALRA BACKS DOWN ON POLICE BILL LANGUAGE

AB 655, authored by Assemblyman Ash Kalra, D-San Jose, was intended to remove white supremacists and other extremists from the ranks of California’s law enforcement.

As it turned out, the bill’s language went a little further than that.

As a Bee fact check pointed out, the language of the bill could be construed to apply to evangelical Christians, Catholics or even registered Republicans.

The California Family Council was the first to point out the bill’s overly broad language, and was quick to condemn the bill.

Now, it appears Kalra is backing down.

In an interview with KPIX CBS, Kalra said he has amended the bill to remove the language that drew consternation.

“We have put in amendments to remove the specificity regarding denial of constitutional rights. Because, you do have the First Amendment right to be part of groups that may differ in opinion,” Kalra said in the KPIX interview.

The California Family Council declared victory in an email blast Friday afternoon.

“We thank Assemblyman Kalra for listening to our concerns and revising AB 655 to respect the constitutional rights

of peace officers," CFC President Jonathan Keller said in a statement. "Jesus said 'there is no greater love than to lay down one's life for one's friends.' California Christians serving as police strive to sacrificially love their communities and treat every person with honesty and fairness. California should want more people of faith in law enforcement, not fewer."

CFT RE-BRANDS

The California Federation of Teachers announced Friday that it is re-branding as CFT — A Union of Educators and Classified Professionals. The decision to re-brand was made at the organization's biennial convention, which took place Friday and Saturday.

The organization also sports a new shield-like logo.

"The new name and updated logo better reflects the expansive role CFT members play in California's educational settings, and reflects their commitment to stand together for schools, students, and their profession," according to a CFT statement.

The union represents 120,000 teachers, bus drivers, faculty members, cafeteria workers, counselors, custodians, librarians, para educators, school nurses and more.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

"I never thought a kid born in the Philippines who came here and had these big dreams could ever say that they were nominated to be the next attorney general."

- Assemblyman Rob Bonta, nominee for the next California attorney general, in a conversation with Gov. Gavin Newsom shared by the governor's office Twitter account.

Best of the Bee:

Mysterious disease killing young California bears in Tahoe. One symptom: fearlessness, via Ryan SabalowCalifornia paying $2.1 million to settle state worker's lawsuit over office chair, via Wes VenteicherWill a warning to drug dealers decrease overdose deaths? California families want to try, via Andrew Sheeler

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